

MARLENA A. BRANHAM

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EDUCATION

UNIVERSITY OF MICHIGAN, SCHOOL OF INFORMATION UX Research and Design (MSI)

Ann Arbor, MI
Aug 2023 – May 2025

- Graduate Certificate in Advanced Studies of Innovation and Entrepreneurship, U-M College of Engineering
- UMSI Inclusive Leaders in Information, National Society of Black Engineers (NSBE), Adobe Campus Ambassador

UNIVERSITY OF MICHIGAN, COLLEGE OF LSA Bachelor of Arts (BA), Biopsychology, Cognition, and Neuroscience

Ann Arbor, MI
June 2017 – Dec 2021

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

MARLENARIELLEE Freelance Social Media Marketing/Content Creation

Michigan/Arizona
Mar 2023 - Present

- Grew a cross-platform community to ~15K, with 80%+ YoY growth as “@marlenariellee”.
- Built and managed a self-generated pipeline of brand collaborations across beauty, wellness, food & beverage, and consumer apps; owned outreach, scoping/SOW, negotiation, close, maintaining CRM hygiene and post-sale delivery.

HERBTROPIA CO. CEO and Founder

Michigan/Arizona
March 2023 – Present

- Stood up a partner GTM (ICP, value props, outreach cadences, deck/collateral) and ran discovery to convert prospects into pilots; collaborated with delivery to hand off scopes, timelines, and success metrics.
- Secured non-dilutive funding (NSF I-Corps; ZLI Eugene Applebaum; Optimize), de-risking early builds and validating demand via external review.

UNIVERSITY OF MICHIGAN Graduate Student Instructor, SI 429: Online Communities

Ann Arbor, MI
Jan 2025 – May 2025

- Facilitated discussions and mentorship for 60+ UX undergraduate students; designed activities that connected community theory to platform mechanics and moderation trade-offs.
- Created feedback rubrics and office-hour guides that improved clarity of expectations and accelerated student iteration cycles.

Instructional Aide, SI 505: Career and Internship Preparation Studio

Oct 2024 – Dec 2024

- Evaluated assignments and provided in-depth feedback for 45+ UX graduate students.
- Designed instructional materials that helped students navigate career planning and professional branding.

ANN ARBOR SPARK Product Development Intern, Digital Summer Clinic

Ann Arbor, MI
May 2024 – August 2024

- Conducted a comprehensive market analysis for APT Solar Solutions, delivering key research insights influencing product development investments in smart city expansion.
- Collaborated with executives to forecast five-year product development opportunities, aligning strategies with business objectives, and driving an increase in market share.

HAPPIERME Business Strategy Consultant, Future Executive in Training Participant

Remote
Apr 2024 – Jan 2025

- Launched a campus ambassador program (10+ schools) with repeatable sourcing, screening, and pitch flows; created templates for proposals and partner onboarding to speed time-to-live.
- Developed 3 scaling initiatives for the release of the HappierMe Teen App across weekly CEO mentorship sessions.

SKILLS

User Research, Product Development, Strategy, Prototyping, Project and Program Management, Digital Marketing, UX/UI Design, Google Analytics, MS Office 360, Figma, Adobe Tools, Canva, Data Analytics, Data Entry